

We need to talk about Friedrich

送信者: POLITICO Brussels Playbook 受信日時: 2026-10-02 13:51

【メール原文】

Presented by Amazon By GABRIEL GAVIN with SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin. Tomorrow is German Unity Day, 36 years after the disso

Presented by Amazon

By GABRIEL GAVIN

with SEBASTIAN STARCEVIC

PRESENTED BY

Send tips here | Follow us @gerardofortuna @NicholasVinocur @GabrielGavin | Listen to Playbook and view in your browser

GOOD MORNING — I'm Gabriel Gavin. Tomorrow is German Unity Day, 36 years after the dissolution of East Germany, but as Chancellor Friedrich Merz is finding out, unity is getting harder to come by ...

In today's Playbook:

— A psychiatrist treating burned-out EU officials says the Commission should do more to cover the cost of their care.

— Europe's frontline states want the bloc to get serious about Russian hybrid attacks.

— Faces in the crowd: Pope Leo XIV, Thomas Van der Poorten, Patrick Collison, Hannah Neumann, Hristijan Mickoski, Maroš Šefčovič, Nicolas Mavraganis, Zack Polanski and more ...

On today's Brussels Playbook Week Ender podcast: Sarah speaks to security expert Elisabeth Braw about the EU's response to Russia's hybrid attacks and the invisible war happening under the sea.

**A message from Amazon: 60% of sales on Amazon come from independent sellers like Lucas from Novoma in Toulouse, France. Founded to make well-being accessible, Novoma now reaches customers across Europe with Amazon—growing beyond its home market while staying rooted locally. Learn how Amazon helps European small businesses grow. **

DRIVING THE DAY

IT HURTS TO BE MERZ: European capitals are preparing for the prospect that German Chancellor Friedrich Merz could lose power — or at least become embroiled in a domestic political fight that pulls his attention away from the battle over the EU budget.

Wie sieht der Plan aus? At least two national governments have held internal war-gaming sessions on what happens if Merz's fragile coalition collapses or he is replaced, according to two officials granted

anonymity to speak on the sensitive talks. The sessions included mapping out what a fall would mean for negotiations over the proposed €2 trillion budget, since Merz leads the group of countries seeking “hundreds of billions of euros” in cuts.

Setting sun: With the far right notching up a string of election victories and the CDU-SPD coalition split on key policy decisions, German newspapers are declaring Kanzlerdämmerung — the chancellor’s twilight.

Diplomats see three ways out: The government collapses, Merz resigns or he plows ahead despite the growing distractions at home. But with the far-right Alternative for Germany leading the polls, “all coalition partners know that they have a great deal to lose from early elections” and will do whatever they can to avoid them, said German Green MEP Hannah Neumann.

No Mr. Compromise: The chancellor’s domestic weakness is unlikely to trigger a climbdown on the EU budget, three diplomats told Playbook. Merz will take a particularly hard line because he needs a win at home, one said. If he is forced to step down, a successor would likely follow his budget lead, according to another. Nobody “would be able to be more flexible than Merz is” on the budget because there’s no appetite in Germany for vastly increased EU payments, they said.

Keep plugging away: Those who know Merz say he won’t be distracted by his domestic woes. “Other politicians might say ‘OK, I focus less on EU politics.’ For him it’s just the opposite: It’s an additional incentive to show leadership in Europe,” said a person familiar with the chancellor’s thinking. On Thursday Merz did just that, making a landmark speech on the need to support Ukraine through the winter to convince a sometimes wavering public.

But domestic politics is already reshaping Berlin’s approach. Germany has backed away from a battle it would previously have fought over the Commission’s push to squeeze cheap imports from China . German manufacturing backs the bid, and the coalition hopes it can help stem the deindustrialization driving support for the far right. According to two national officials, Germany will reverse its historic opposition and is drafting a joint letter with France to the Commission backing the trade instruments.

Up or down: With negotiations over the EU budget heating up, Merz could be in for a brawl in Brussels — not just at home. Read the full story from me and Frida Preuß [here](#).

BIG AND BREAKING

FUELING INFLATION: President Donald Trump’s threat to halt diesel exports to Europe could send prices skyrocketing and put small and medium-sized firms out of business , my colleague Martina Sapio writes.

The Trump administration last night stepped up pressure on European allies to release diesel reserves, including a post on X from Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent urging them to make supplies available “immediately.” Earlier, France, Germany, Britain, Italy, Ireland and the European Commission agreed at an emergency meeting to respond to Washington with “one voice,” Ben Munster reports.

DRONE PROBE: An undetonated bomb used in the Leipzig attack has resurrected a two-year-old investigation into explosives found at a graveyard in Lithuania, as authorities uncover the networks used for Russian attacks on EU soil .

NOT THERE YET: The EU and China still have work to do to reach a trade deal after months of “tough” talks, Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič told POLITICO on the sidelines of the G20 meeting in Milwaukee. He’ll head to Beijing next week for a “super crucial” meeting with Chinese Commerce Minister Wang Wentao.

APPLICATION REJECTED: Some EU members are pushing to temporarily suspend asylum applications in emergencies like the crisis in Ceuta this summer, my colleague Hanne Cokelaere reports .

BURNOUT IN THE BERLAYMONT

THE EU’S MENTAL HEALTH BILL: EU officials needing psychiatric care to deal with workplace trauma end up paying a hefty chunk of the bill themselves, warned a Brussels psychiatrist who treats burned-out European Commission staff.

Mind the gap: Thomas Van der Poorten, president of the Belgian Federation of Outpatient Psychiatry, told Sebastian Starcevic the institution must do more. The roughly €60 per session reimbursed by JSIS, the EU’s health insurance scheme for staff, can fall well short of what private psychiatrists charge — leaving employees to cover the rest, he said.

“The institutions are not bystanders to Europe’s workplace mental health crisis — they seem to actively contribute to one,” said Van der Poorten, who estimated that about 80% of his patients working at the Commission come to him after experiencing some form of workplace harassment. He argued the institution should set an “exemplary” standard in providing mental health care, given the harm he says is induced by toxic managers.

The reimbursement ceilings “are not enough,” agreed Nicolas Mavraganis, president of Union Syndicale Fédérale, the EU’s staff union umbrella group, highlighting how many staff report facing harassment. The ceiling was last raised in 2023 from €50, which is comparable to the Belgian state health insurance rebate, after a 15-year freeze.

Financial toll: While EU officials are typically highly paid and have job security, meaning they can presumably afford good care, Van der Poorten pointed out many of his patients have been off work for a while by the time they see him. “It’s the story of most mental health patients.”

Commission responds: A Commission spokesperson told Playbook the institution takes its “duty of care” toward staff facing mental health issues seriously and pointed to a “broad range” of “support mechanisms,” including support groups, an “Empathy Network” and an HR helpline.

20-SECOND PLAYBOOK PRIMER

The Rhine Group recently finished its first meeting, but what is it? It’s a new organization made up of CEOs, economists, academics and tech entrepreneurs that wants to develop reforms outside the confines of the EU’s complex machinery. It was founded by Mario Draghi, the former Italian prime minister and European Central Bank chief, and Stripe founder Patrick Collison. Draghi, you may recall, authored a 2024 report on European competitiveness.

TALK TO PLAYBOOK: WhatsApp us on +32 491 050629 and listen from 7 a.m. to hear if we give you a shout-out.

NOT-SO-HYBRID WAR

FRONTIER STATES WANT BRUSSELS TO GET SERIOUS: Europe's upcoming security strategy must include more intelligence sharing, investment in security services and rapid response capabilities, Estonian Foreign Minister Margus Tsahkna told Playbook's Zoya Sheftalovich.

This is war: Russia's attacks on EU countries are "not like the classical military invasion" people might picture, but amount to "some kind of war," Tsahkna said. Moscow is trying to "divide our societies, divide our unity and play with fear."

The strategy — which is expected later this year — should distinguish sabotage and cyberattacks from the threat of a full-scale military assault, he said. The goal should be to prevent attacks, avoid panic if they happen, and show a united front. "Business as usual is not coming back."

Make the stooges pay: Tsahkna urged EU countries to move swiftly against saboteurs caught doing the Kremlin's dirty work, publicly attribute attacks and make the consequences clear. "Mainly they are not ideological, they are just people ... after some easy money," he said of those recruited to carry out attacks. The message to them should be: "If you do anything in our territories, we will catch you and we will put you in prison for years ... so think many times before" agreeing to participate.

**The future of Europe is being shaped by decisions on technology, energy, defense, mobility and affordability. Join us in Brussels on November 5 to discuss these priorities with key European decisionmakers and help inform the questions Europeans will be asked in 2027. Apply to join. **

6 MORE THINGS GETTING US TALKING

CASH COMING: The EU will speed up disbursement of €45 billion in much-needed loan funding earmarked for Ukraine in 2027 after striking a deal yesterday .

NO RULES: Vladimir Putin has told his military chiefs to abandon the rules of war as Russia steps up its offensive against Ukraine, Volodymyr Zelenskyy has told the FT .

CAN EU DO IT? A new video game made by the Socialists and Democrats challenges users to launch a European electric car, while juggling tricky manufacturing decisions and geopolitical shocks. It's harder than it looks. Have a go here .

DON'T USE US TO GET AT TRUMP: Albania's PM Edi Rama is urging U.S. Democrats not to jump on the backlash against a planned luxury resort backed by Donald Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner, according to our colleagues at WELT . (WELT is owned by Axel Springer, POLITICO's parent company.)

STUCK ON THE SILK ROAD: NATO wants to strengthen its ties with Armenia and Azerbaijan — but its plans are being held up by a row between France and Turkey , Victor Jack reports.

AI DILEMMA: In this week's Declassified column, Paul Dallison wonders if you should invest in artificial intelligence when there's a chance it might kill us all .

BRUSSELS CORNER

WEATHER: Sunny intervals. High 20C.

YOU MADE IT TO THE WEEKEND: The forecast is for dry weather, but there's plenty to do indoors or out ...

Down the drain: For something totally different, entrance to the Sewer Museum is free on the first Sunday of every month. Guided tours are also free but places are limited, so you'll have to book.

Books before looks: Over in Forest, the WIELS Art Book Fair runs Saturday and Sunday from 11 a.m. to 6 p.m., with free entry. Expect independent publishers, artist books, zines, limited editions, readings, talks, signings and performances.

Paper trail: Art on Paper takes over Shed 1 at Tour & Taxis from 11 a.m. to 6 p.m. Saturday and Sunday. Around 60 international galleries are showing everything from Old Masters to contemporary works on paper for the fair's 10th anniversary.

Two options for browsers: Tomorrow brings the free Creative Women's Market to Maison de la Création at Bockstael, showcasing crafts by local women creators. On Sunday, Brussels Vintage Market takes over Halles Saint-Géry from 10 a.m. to 6 p.m., with clothes, vinyl, jewelry, accessories and small furniture.

Bodies in motion: Dance fans get the Alvin Ailey American Dance Theater at Forest National, with performances tomorrow at 8 p.m. and Sunday at 6 p.m. For more airborne entertainment, Cirque du Soleil's "OVO" is entering its final Brussels weekend at ING Arena, with 53 acrobats and musicians doing things your Playbook author certainly cannot.

On chante en français: Finally, FrancoFaune offers the smaller-stage option: Mia Lena + Clelia at Superfourchette on Saturday, then Vilain Tigre + Moite Moite at BAMP on Sunday. Both are €15 (or €12 in advance) — for those who prefer discovering their next favorite francophone act to fighting their way out of an arena.

TOP OF THE PLAYBOOKS

Berlin: Friedrich Merz's rebuke of Social Democratic Finance Minister Lars Klingbeil's plans for a sugar tax has added to a growing rift in the governing coalition.

Paris: Politicians are trading blame over the eruption of high school protests across France on Thursday, while Sébastien Lecornu's government struggles to contain the fallout.

London: Green Leader Zack Polanski takes the stage at his party's annual conference hoping to revive its flagging momentum, six days before he contests a parliamentary by-election.

Washington: New Jersey's Democratic Governor Mikie Sherrill came through a local scandal relatively unscathed — and she's now poised to become a national power broker in 2028.

Ottawa: Quebec is set to elect a new premier Monday, with separatist leader Paul St-Pierre Plamondon promising a third independence referendum if he wins.

Canberra: The right-wing nationalist One Nation is on track to win a slim majority in the state of New South Wales, according to a new analysis.

AGENDA

— Commission President Ursula von der Leyen continues her visit to the Western Balkans in North Macedonia, where she meets President Gordana Siljanovska-Davkova and Prime Minister Hristijan Mickoski in Skopje. Press conference with Mickoski at 1:45 p.m. Watch live .

— Justice and Home Affairs Council (Justice) in Luxembourg. Arrivals and doorsteps from 9 a.m. Press conference with Ireland's Justice Minister Jim O'Callaghan and EU Justice Commissioner Michael McGrath from 3:45 p.m. Watch live .

— EU High Representative Kaja Kallas is in Rome where she meets Pope Leo XIV and the Vatican's Secretary of State Cardinal Pietro Parolin. She'll also meet Italy's Foreign Minister Antonio Tajani and Defense Minister Guido Crosetto.

— Commission Executive Vice President Henna Virkkunen meets Finnish President Alexander Stubb in Helsinki.

— Energy Commissioner Dan Jørgensen co-chairs the EU-Azerbaijan Energy Dialogue.

— Agriculture Commissioner Christophe Hansen chairs a meeting of the European Board on Agriculture and Food.

— European Parliament President Roberta Metsola meets Dutch Prime Minister Rob Jetten at The Hague at 5 p.m.

— Mediterranean Commissioner Dubravka Šuica attends the EuroMediterranean Water Forum in Rome.

BIRTHDAYS

MEPs Kris Van Dijck and Benoît Cassart; Belgium's Coreper II spokesperson Stanley Matthys; former MEP Stasys Jakeliūnas; POLITICO's Pieter Haeck; BlackRock's Antony Manchester; European Commission's Andreana Stankova, Madalina Mocanu and Franck Arrii; Orfeo's Anne Deltour; Rapporteur's Eddy Wax.

Celebrating Saturday: Former MEP Pascal Durand; President of the European Investment Bank Nadia Calviño; Bayer's Hartwig Wendt; the Socialists and Democrats Group's Álvaro Gutiérrez Boada; ESM's former Managing Director Klaus Regling; POLITICO's Dionisios Sturis; journalist Sonya Diehn; Forefront Advisers' Jenna Bezahaf; Follow the Money's Leonie Kijewski. German Unity Day.

Celebrating Sunday: MEPs Aleksandar Nikolić, Petra Steger and Alessandro Zan; POLITICO's Tom Nicholson; Sally Low, founder of LOW Europe; Ana Botín, executive chair of Santander Group and POLITICO 28 alum.

Playbook is brought to you by POLITICO's EU Politics team: Gerardo Fortuna, Nicholas Vinocur, Gabriel Gavin, Zoya Sheftalovich, Max Griera, Mari Eccles, Hanne Cokelaere and Sebastian Starcevic. And: reporters Milena Wälde and Daria Zakharova, editors Alex Spence and James Panichi, and producers Dean Southwell and Hugh Kapernaros.

****A message from Amazon:** Lucas Pinos' Novoma began with a simple ambition: to make well-being accessible to everyone. Founded in Toulouse, France, Novoma set out to create food supplements built

on transparency, trust, and scientific rigor. As demand grew, Amazon helped Novoma reach customers across Europe.” Amazon enabled us, as a small business, to reach new markets where we hadn’t existed before, and drive strong growth in just one year,” says Lucas. Novoma is one of thousands of European success stories selling on Amazon. In 2024, EU-based small businesses sold more than 1.3 billion products and generated over €34 billion in sales within the EU alone. Together, these entrepreneurs support an estimated 350,000 jobs across the EU, many in local and regional communities. By providing tools, logistics, and access to customers across borders, Amazon helps small businesses, like Novoma, grow beyond their local markets while staying rooted in their communities. Learn more about how Amazon helps European businesses thrive in our latest EU Small and Medium Enterprises Impact Report at AboutAmazon.eu. **

SUBSCRIBE to the POLITICO newsletter family: Brussels Playbook | London Playbook | London Playbook PM | Playbook Paris | Berlin Playbook | Sunday Crunch | EU Influence | London Influence | D.C. Playbook | D.C. Influence | Canada Playbook | POLITICO Forecast | Canberra Playbook | All our POLITICO Pro policy morning newsletters

This email was sent to shondo@iies.co.jp

[Update your preferences](#) | [Unsubscribe from this email](#) | [Unsubscribe from all emails](#)

POLITICO SRL · Rue de la Loi 62 · Brussels 1040 · Belgium